The Book of Mormon Translation

The Belief Files

Case File 002

Historical investigation and biblical assessment

Beyond the Message | Religion Comparison | November 2026

Investigation summary

Joseph Smith claimed that the Book of Mormon came from an ancient record on metal plates and that God enabled him to translate it into English. The historical question is larger than whether he dictated a lengthy book. It concerns the source of that book and the authority claimed for it.

The surviving record includes nineteenth-century manuscripts, an 1830 printed edition, two published group statements about the plates, Smith's own explanations, and accounts from people involved in the work. Some records are close to the events; several detailed descriptions of the process were recorded decades later. These sources do not all answer the same question.

Assessment: There is strong evidence for the production of the English text through dictation and substantial testimony from participants who affirmed a divine origin. The records reviewed here do not independently establish an ancient source text or a supernatural translation. They also do not establish that Smith knowingly committed fraud. The distinction between those findings is central to this case.

This investigation uses Jamie Dennis's existing research packet as its starting point, with primary records and official LDS explanations checked for this case. Historical conclusions and the project's evangelical Christian assessment are identified separately. [1-2]

The claim under investigation

The central LDS claim is that **Joseph Smith translated an authentic ancient record by divine power, producing scripture that bears authoritative witness to Jesus Christ.** This combines several propositions:

- An ancient record existed on the plates described by Smith.
- Smith obtained that record through the events he reported.
- God enabled the production of an English rendering of its contents.
- The resulting book deserves recognition as scripture.

Evidence for one proposition does not automatically establish all four. A scribe can attest that Smith dictated words without knowing their ultimate source. A witness can report handling an object without independently establishing its date or translating its inscriptions. A reader can find the book spiritually meaningful without thereby settling its historical origin.

LDS teaching does not present the process as ordinary translation by a trained linguist. Its official essay acknowledges interpreters and a separate seer stone and describes a revelatory process. Assessing the claim fairly therefore requires examining the stated method, rather than assuming the Church claims conventional language study. The resulting question remains demanding: what warrants identifying the dictated English as a faithful, divinely authorized rendering of an ancient record? [2]

How this investigation weighs evidence

Four distinctions guide the inquiry:

- **Event and record:** When did something reportedly happen, and when was the surviving account written or published?
- **Observation and interpretation:** What did someone say they saw or heard, and what did they believe it meant?
- **Access and independence:** Could the person observe the relevant event? Are several reports separate accounts or repetitions of a shared statement?
- **Historical and theological judgment:** Does the evidence establish a human action, support an explanation, or require a judgment about revelation?

A participant's religious commitment does not invalidate that person's testimony. A critic's hostility does not invalidate every criticism. Both may affect selection, wording, memory, or interpretation. Those possibilities must be assessed against the actual record, not used as shortcuts to a verdict.

In this case, **dictation** means speaking words for a scribe to record. **Translation** names the claimed relationship between those English words and an earlier language. **Revelation** names the claimed divine source of the process. Demonstrating dictation alone does not demonstrate the other two.

The historical timeline

Date	Event or record	Evidential significance
1823	Smith later reported an angelic visitation concerning a buried record.	Part of his origin claim, preserved in later accounts.
September 1827	Smith reported receiving the plates.	A reported event, not an independently dated archaeological recovery.
1828	An early portion, described as 116 manuscript pages, was lost after Harris took it away.	The loss is central to Smith's 1830 preface and later participant accounts.
April to June 1829	The principal period of production of the present English text, chiefly with Oliver Cowdery.	The broad chronology is supported by manuscript and historical research.
August 1829	A newspaper described a hat-based method; Harris arranged financial support for printing.	Early evidence that the method was being reported; a documented financial commitment.
1830	The Book of Mormon was published, including the Three and Eight Witnesses statements.	Public texts close to the production period, available for inspection.
1831 and 1834	A conference statement attributed to Smith and a letter by Cowdery addressed the translation.	Earlier retrospective evidence; the surviving conference copy dates to 1838.
1859 to 1887	Harris, Emma Smith, and David Whitmer supplied detailed later accounts.	Important participant testimony with substantial gaps between event and recording.

The first two entries report Smith's claims. The later entries concern surviving records or historically reconstructable activity. The table does not assign every event the same level of verification. [3-12, 16, 20]

Exhibit one The English manuscripts

Fragments of the original manuscript survive, along with a printer's manuscript and the first printed edition. The original and printer's manuscripts are different artifacts: the former comes from the production process; the latter largely served as a copy prepared for publication. Confusing them can create misleading claims about what a particular page proves. [4-5]

The original manuscript's writing, corrections, and scribal features provide material evidence of a nineteenth-century English text taking shape. The Joseph Smith Papers editors identify features consistent with oral dictation, including errors more readily explained by hearing than by visually copying. Their analysis also discusses immediate corrections and the relationship between dictation and printing. [6]

What this supports: A real text-production process occurred, with scribes recording Smith's words. The surviving materials provide evidence stronger than a later recollection alone.

What this does not establish: An English manuscript does not supply its own ancient-language source. Oral delivery is compatible with more than one explanation, including claimed revelation, prepared composition, improvisation, remembered material, or a mixture of processes. These possibilities require separate evidence; listing them does not demonstrate that any one occurred.

The research packet also raises linguistic claims about a non-English foundation. Those require specialist analysis of particular features, comparison texts, and alternative explanations. Neither unusual grammar nor biblical-sounding English should be treated here as a demonstrated identification of the language on the reported plates. [1, 6]

Exhibit two The instruments and the hat

The official LDS account distinguishes interpreters reportedly received with the plates from a separate seer stone. It also acknowledges Smith's earlier use of a stone in treasure seeking. Later terminology can obscure the distinction because the expression Urim and Thummim was used broadly in accounts of the translation. A source using that expression should not automatically be read as identifying one particular object in every session. [2]

A newspaper account published in August 1829 described spectacles placed in a hat. This matters because the hat description was circulating near the production period. The report was hostile and secondhand, however, and referred to spectacles; it cannot be treated as direct observation of every later-described stone procedure. [8]

In a letter dated September 7, 1834, Cowdery recalled writing as Smith dictated and affirmed his belief that the process was inspired. His reference to the interpreters is valuable testimony from a principal scribe, approximately five years after the work. It is not a session-by-session procedural record. [7]

Emma Smith's 1879 interview described dictation with Smith's face in a hat and a stone inside. She denied seeing a manuscript or book from which he read. She also described feeling the covered plates, rather than uncovering and examining them. These are distinct claims: participation in dictation, an observation about visible materials, and a tactile experience involving a covered object. [10]

Whitmer's 1887 account similarly described a stone and hat, explaining that English words appeared and that corrections were made before the next portion appeared. His participation gives his account historical importance. Yet another person could observe Smith's actions and the scribe's work without seeing what Smith allegedly perceived inside the instrument. The explanation of appearing words must be distinguished from directly observable movement and speech. [12]

Smith did not leave a complete technical explanation. Minutes of an October 1831 meeting attribute to him a refusal to disclose all the particulars; the surviving copy of those minutes was made in 1838. That limits reconstruction. It does not, by itself, establish either divine secrecy or concealment of fraud. [9]

Exhibit three The lost 116 pages

Smith's preface to the 1830 edition publicly acknowledged the loss of 116 manuscript pages. He explained the decision not to reproduce the same material by referring to an intended attempt to alter the lost text and discredit him. Doctrine and Covenants 10 presents the related instruction to translate another portion of the record. [3, 17]

Three points need to remain separate:

1. The early movement acknowledged that an initial manuscript portion was missing.
2. Smith supplied a religious explanation for why the replacement would cover different material.
3. The claim that adversaries planned to alter the missing pages is not independently established merely because his explanation says so.

The missing pages are not available for a controlled comparison with a second rendering. That prevents using this incident as a direct repeat-translation test. It also prevents claiming that such a test proved failure: no surviving side-by-side comparison demonstrates that Smith attempted and failed to reproduce them.

The fair question is whether the explanation is persuasive in light of the available evidence. It is not fair to identify an unproved thief, assert that alterations actually occurred, or state as a documented fact that Smith was incapable of reproducing the passage.

Exhibit four The disputed expert endorsement

The Harris account preserved in Joseph Smith's history says that Charles Anthon approved copied characters and their translation, then withdrew a certificate after hearing about the angelic origin of the record. That is one side of a disputed encounter. [16]

In an 1834 letter published by Eber D. Howe, Anthon denied having authenticated the characters as reformed Egyptian and described his suspicion of a hoax. This is a retrospective account from the scholar himself, transmitted in a strongly critical publication. His accusation must be evaluated as testimony, not adopted as a proven conclusion. [15]

The accounts support that a consultation took place while disagreeing sharply about what it established. They do not provide this investigation with an agreed, surviving certification and an authenticated ancient source text against which the English book can be checked.

Accordingly, the Anthon encounter should not be advertised as an uncontested scholarly verification of the Book of Mormon. Conversely, Anthon's rejection does not, by itself, identify how the entire English text was produced. It challenges a particular endorsement claim.

Exhibit five The plate witnesses

The 1830 edition contains **two collective witness statements with eleven names**. That is meaningful evidence, but it is not eleven separately preserved, independently recorded examinations of the translation. [13-14]

Witness group	What its published statement claims	What the statement does not supply
The Three	An angel showed the plates and engravings; a divine voice affirmed the translation. Names: Oliver Cowdery, David Whitmer, Martin Harris.	An independent language analysis or a translation they performed themselves.

Witness group	What its published statement claims	What the statement does not supply
The Eight	Smith showed them plates with the appearance of gold; they handled the leaves and saw engravings.	A stated angelic encounter in this testimony, metallurgical testing, or an independently established ancient date.

The Eight were Christian Whitmer, Jacob Whitmer, Peter Whitmer Jr., John Whitmer, Hiram Page, Joseph Smith Sr., Hyrum Smith, and Samuel H. Smith. Family and social relationships matter when considering independence. They do not establish that the men invented their testimony. Likewise, the Three's religious interpretation does not justify rewriting their statement as if they admitted that nothing happened.

The different claims should be allowed to remain different. The Three describe an explicitly supernatural encounter. The Eight emphasize viewing and handling. A single label such as purely physical or merely visionary can hide those distinctions.

Whitmer's later affirmation is especially relevant because he continued to defend the Book of Mormon while rejecting important later claims and actions associated with Smith. That complicates an explanation based solely on continuing institutional loyalty. His persistence is evidence of commitment; it does not convert the original experience into an independently reproducible examination. [12]

The official LDS discussion presents the witnesses' continuing affirmations as a major argument for the book. This case recognizes the force of that argument while distinguishing sustained testimony from external verification of ancient origin. [22]

Assessing the principal accounts

Person and surviving record	Reason to take it seriously	Limit to keep in view
Oliver Cowdery, 1834 letter	Principal scribe; earlier than the detailed late interviews; direct involvement in dictation.	Written about five years later; its affirmation of inspiration exceeds what handwriting alone can establish.
Emma Smith, 1879 interview	Participating scribe and household observer; described visible working conditions and a covered object.	About fifty years later; recorded by her son and published after her death; her observations do not cover every session.
Martin Harris, 1859 interview	Early scribe, financial supporter, and one of the Three; personal involvement in several relevant events.	About thirty years later and mediated by an interviewer; separate reported episodes must not be blended into one observation.
David Whitmer, 1887 publication	Participant who published an explicit affirmation despite estrangement from Smith's later movement.	About fifty-eight years later; detailed mechanics include an explanation of what Smith allegedly saw.

These limits affect weight, not automatic admissibility. Late memories can preserve real events and can also reflect later vocabulary or interpretation. Agreement among accounts deserves attention, but agreement may concern broad actions while leaving the exact instrument, sequence, or wording uncertain. [7, 10-12]

The strongest LDS argument

A fair investigation should state the affirmative case in a form believers can recognize. It combines a substantial text produced in a concentrated period, the surviving scribal record, participants' descriptions of dictation, Emma's denial of visible source materials, the plate testimonies, and continued affirmation by witnesses. For LDS readers, prayerful engagement with the book provides a further avenue of confirmation. [2, 6-7, 10, 12-14, 18]

Taken together, these points deserve more serious consideration than a dismissal based on Smith's limited schooling or the unfamiliarity of the instruments. The experience described by participants was significant to them.

The next step, however, is to ask which part of the origin claim each point supports. Speed and sustained testimony may strengthen an argument without independently identifying an ancient language or proving divine authorization. A cumulative case is strongest when its different evidential contributions are stated accurately.

Competing explanations

The surviving record does not require a choice between an unquestionable miracle and an already-proven conspiracy. These are explanatory models to examine, not verdicts this file has demonstrated.

Divinely enabled translation

This accepts the central LDS explanation: an ancient record and divine assistance account for the English book. It accommodates the participants' own religious interpretation and treats the instruments as means God chose to use.

Its central evidential burden is connecting observed dictation and reported encounters to an authentic ancient source and trustworthy revelation. Material that establishes nineteenth-century production does not independently complete that connection. Prayer and spiritual experience also introduce a theological judgment about how revelation is recognized.

Deliberate human production

This proposes that Smith knowingly produced a human composition while presenting it as an ancient revelation. The model does not require ancient plates or appearing words to explain the existence of an English manuscript.

To establish it historically, an investigator needs positive evidence for planning, source use, deception, or a workable composition process. Merely observing that a human-authorship explanation is possible does not show which process occurred. Limited formal schooling does not prove incapacity; neither does a claim of hidden preparation count as evidence that such preparation happened.

Sincere religious interpretation

This proposes that Smith or some participants sincerely interpreted an unusual religious experience as revelation, without requiring every claimed supernatural explanation to be historically correct.

It can help explain sincere conviction without assuming that all participants had identical access or intentions. Its limit is that sincerity cannot be directly read from a manuscript, and a precise account of private experience remains difficult to demonstrate. This case makes no medical diagnosis and does not use hallucination as a substitute for evidence.

A mixed or developing process

This allows different levels of knowledge, preparation, belief, and later recollection among participants. It can accommodate variation in descriptions without assuming one motive explains everyone.

Its weakness is flexibility: an explanation that can absorb every possible outcome may become difficult to test. A useful version must identify particular records that support particular developments, rather than rely on an undefined mixture.

The present evidence permits comparing these models more confidently than it permits reconstructing Smith's private mental process. The burden of

proving divine translation differs from the burden of proving intentional fraud; failure to establish one does not automatically establish the other.

Motives benefits and costs

Money, authority, and personal relationships are legitimate investigative questions. They are not a ready-made finding of guilt. For each proposed motive, ask: what benefit existed at the relevant time, who received it, what did it cost, and what evidence connects it to a knowingly false claim?

Money: The Joseph Smith Papers' documentary overview identifies Harris's August 1829 mortgage as support for printing. That is evidence of a substantial financial commitment by a participant. It complicates a casual suggestion that everyone involved enjoyed an effortless profit. It does not establish that every later financial arrangement was disinterested. This case relies on the documentary overview rather than claiming a new examination of the mortgage itself. [20]

Authority: Presenting a book as revelation can confer religious authority on the person presenting it. That creates a possible incentive worthy of scrutiny. Religious authority can also be sought or accepted sincerely; the existence of a leadership role does not demonstrate a secret plan to deceive.

Relationships: Family and community connections may influence trust, loyalty, and access. They also help explain how a movement organized practical work. A connection is not equivalent to proof of collusion.

Later plural-marriage evidence belongs in its own case. Importing later conduct into this one cannot, without an additional evidential link, establish what Smith intended during the 1829 dictation. Benefits, sacrifices, and subsequent conflict should inform an inquiry without being made to answer questions they cannot settle.

A biblical assessment

This section states the project's **evangelical and Trinitarian Christian assessment**. It is a theological evaluation of the claim, not an additional manuscript finding. LDS readers accept biblical authority while interpreting revelation, restoration, and scripture differently. Defining that difference is more useful than assuming agreement on every term.

Test the message as well as the experience

Galatians 1:6-9 warns against accepting a different gospel even if its messenger is presented as an angel. In context, Paul defends the gospel already proclaimed to the Galatians. An angelic claim therefore cannot serve as its own exemption from examination.

First John 4:1-3 tells readers to test spiritual claims and supplies a Christological test in its setting. It should not be reduced to a password that settles every later doctrinal question. Nor should an investigator say that LDS belief simply omits Jesus: the disagreement concerns the identity and teaching attributed to him, among other matters.

The application is specific: examine the resulting teaching about God, Christ, salvation, and authority against the apostolic writings. This translation case identifies the need for that comparison; it does not pretend to have completed every doctrinal comparison in the project. [21]

Examine the instruments in biblical context

Deuteronomy 18:9-14 prohibits divination and related practices. That makes the reported treasure-seeking background relevant to Christian evaluation. It does not remove the need to define the practice being examined and demonstrate why a particular use belongs in the prohibited category.

Exodus 28:30 and Numbers 27:21 describe the Urim and Thummim within Israel's priestly setting. These passages show that Scripture includes material instruments associated with seeking divine judgment. They do not describe Smith's stone-and-hat procedure or authorize any later object merely because someone applies the biblical name to it.

Two careless arguments should therefore be avoided: unfamiliar instruments automatically prove demonic activity, and biblical instruments automatically validate Smith's method. The stronger questions concern the claimed authorization, the actual practice, and the message produced. Deuteronomy 13:1-5 also places loyalty to God above the persuasive force of a sign. [21]

Treat prayer as part of discernment

Moroni 10:3-5 calls for reading, pondering, sincere prayer, real intent, and faith in Christ, with confirmation through the Holy Ghost. Describing the LDS invitation as simply having a pleasant feeling is inaccurate. Doctrine and Covenants 9:7-9 addresses Cowdery's attempted translation and should not be silently substituted for Moroni's promise. [18-19]

From this project's Christian perspective, prayer should accompany examination rather than eliminate it. James 1:5 invites asking God for wisdom; it does not name the Book of Mormon or promise that every later claim accepted after prayer is thereby authenticated. Acts 17:10-12 commends examination of Paul's teaching in light of Scripture. A sincere spiritual impression and a historical conclusion can be discussed together without being treated as the same type of evidence. [21]

Apply the same standards to Christian testimony

Luke 1:1-4 expressly discusses sources and transmission. First Corinthians 15:1-8 presents received testimony concerning Jesus's death, burial, resurrection, and appearances. Christians should welcome questions about the dates, authorship, access, and dependence of these records, just as they ask such questions about LDS records.

Paul's reference to more than five hundred is a report about a large group; the passage does not preserve five hundred separate signed accounts. Likewise, eleven names on two Book of Mormon statements should not be advertised as eleven independent surviving depositions. Applying this distinction consistently strengthens the investigation's credibility.

For this project, apostolic Scripture supplies the governing theological standard. That confessional position should be acknowledged openly. It should not be presented as an archaeological discovery, and Revelation 22:18-19 should not be quoted as though its immediate wording explicitly lists and closes a sixty-six-book canon. [21]

Findings and confidence

Finding	Assessment	Reason
An English Book of Mormon text existed by 1830.	Established	Surviving manuscripts and first edition.
Smith dictated substantial portions to scribes.	Strongly supported	Material manuscript evidence and participant accounts.
Instrument-and-hat accounts belong to the historical record.	Well supported	Early reporting and later participant testimony; exact session details vary.
Two published plate statements carried eleven names.	Established	Inspectable statements in the 1830 edition.
Those statements independently verify ancient date and translation accuracy.	Not established	They supply testimony, not a source-language or archaeological audit.
Smith's text was divinely translated from an ancient record.	A religious claim not independently established here	The reviewed evidence does not complete that historical and theological inference.
Smith knowingly fabricated the book for a specified private benefit.	Not established by this case	Possible incentives and explanatory models do not demonstrate intent.

These are judgments about the evidence reviewed, not numerical probabilities or claims that no further evidence could matter. Different

readers may weigh testimony differently. They should still distinguish what a source reports from what they infer from it.

Overall assessment

The strongest historical conclusion concerns the **English book and its production**. The manuscript record, early publication, and participant testimony establish a serious historical phenomenon that deserves investigation. A dismissive account that treats every witness as irrelevant fails to engage the evidence.

The central LDS conclusion goes further: an ancient record was rendered into authoritative scripture through divine power. The sources reviewed here do not independently establish that full chain. The absence of a surviving, publicly examinable ancient source limits direct comparison; Smith's later history reports that the plates were returned to the angel. That explanation is part of the religious claim, not an independently verified recovery or return. [16]

The resulting assessment is neither an authentication nor a finding of proven fraud. It is a defined evidential boundary. Christians evaluating the book should examine the historical testimony seriously and test its claimed gospel and authority against the apostolic writings. Respect for a person does not require accepting that person's conclusion, and disagreement does not justify misrepresenting the testimony.

Read compare and discuss

For a 45 to 60 minute session, read the two witness statements and the selected accounts before discussing explanations. Use the first half for historical evidence and the second for biblical assessment.

1. Which records are closest to 1829? How should a long delay affect the weight of an account without automatically disqualifying it?
2. What could a scribe observe directly? Which parts of the translation explanation required trust in Smith or a religious interpretation?

3. How do the Three and Eight differ? What would be lost by treating them as identical accounts?
4. What does the lost manuscript incident establish? What conclusions are unavailable because the pages do not survive for comparison?
5. What is the strongest point in the LDS case? What additional evidence would help distinguish among the explanations?
6. What would count as evidence against your preferred explanation? Are you asking the same questions of sources you already trust?
7. How do Galatians 1 and First John 4 help a Christian evaluate a revelation claim without turning the discussion into an attack on a believer?

A respectful conversation opener: Ask an LDS friend which evidence they find most persuasive, what they understand translation to mean in this setting, and how they distinguish spiritual confirmation from historical verification. Share your own standard with equal clarity and allow them to correct an inaccurate summary of their position.

Family exercise: Read a short excerpt from one witness statement. Write three columns: what the witness reports, what the witness concludes, and what we would need to examine next. Apply the same exercise to Luke 1:1-4. The aim is careful reading and fairness, rather than pressure to announce an immediate verdict.

Accuracy notes and further research

- The source packet is an organizing resource, not independent corroboration of the events it summarizes.
- This file draws on selected records. It is not a complete inventory of every translation or witness account.
- The newspaper item and several late accounts were consulted in online transcriptions. A critical edition should collate their wording against original page images before relying on small verbal differences.
- Claims about ancient-language grammar, source borrowing, textual complexity, or composition speed require a dedicated specialist study with explicit methods and comparison material.
- The Anthon dispute needs both sides represented. Neither an endorsement nor a fraud verdict should be reported as uncontested.
- Testimony about covered plates, visible plates, engravings, an angel, and a divine voice must retain those distinctions.
- Later revisions to the English text are a separate textual-history question. The existence of corrections does not, without analysis, establish fraud or resolve inspiration.
- Theological conclusions should identify the Christian interpretive position rather than label it a neutral historical finding.

Sources and reading

References identify the record used and its evidential role. Dates of later recollections are supplied to prevent them from being mistaken for contemporary diary entries. Biblical references use the King James Version. Online sources were checked for this preparation in November 2026.

[1] Project research packet. Jamie Dennis, *LDS Gospel Topics Essays .pdf*, 366-page research compilation, Book of Mormon Translation section, packet pages 32-65. Organizing source and prior claim analysis; not a primary historical witness.

[2] Official LDS explanation. The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, *Book of Mormon Translation*, Gospel Topics Essays. Institutional account of the claim, instruments, and spiritual confirmation. Read the essay.

[3] Joseph Smith's early public explanation. Preface to the *Book of Mormon*, 1830 edition, pages iii-iv; preface prepared circa August 1829. Primary printed account of the lost pages and the claimed response. Joseph Smith Papers transcription and images. Read the preface.

[4] Original manuscript. *Original Manuscript of the Book of Mormon*, circa April 12, 1828, to circa July 1, 1829, Joseph Smith Papers. Surviving production manuscript and editorial description. View the manuscript record.

[5] Printer's manuscript. *Printer's Manuscript of the Book of Mormon*, circa August 1829 to circa January 1830, Joseph Smith Papers. Copy prepared for publication; distinct from the original dictation manuscript. View the manuscript record.

[6] Modern manuscript analysis. Joseph Smith Papers, *Introduction to Revelations and Translations Volume 5*. Editorial discussion of chronology, scribes, oral production, corrections, and surviving material. Read the introduction.

[7] Oliver Cowdery's recollection. Letter dated September 7, 1834, published in *Latter Day Saints' Messenger and Advocate* 1, October 1834, page 14; copied into *History, 1834-1836*, pages 47-48. Approximately five years after the principal dictation period; the history copy is later than the original letter. Read the surviving copy.

[8] Early newspaper report. Jonathan A. Hadley, *Golden Bible*, *Palmyra Freeman*, August 11, 1829, page 2. Hostile, secondhand report; consulted in a modern edited transcription. Evidence for early circulation of a hat-method description. Read the transcription.

[9] Joseph Smith on disclosure. *Minutes, October 25-26, 1831*, page 13, Joseph Smith Papers. Surviving version copied in 1838 into Minute Book 2; attributes to Smith a statement about not revealing all the particulars. Read the minutes.

[10] Emma Smith's late interview. *Last Testimony of Sister Emma*, *The Saints' Herald* 26, October 1, 1879, pages 289-290. Interview by Joseph Smith III in February 1879; published after Emma's death. Primary testimony consulted through FAIR's transcription. Read the transcription.

[11] Martin Harris's late interview. Joel Tiffany, *Mormonism II*, *Tiffany's Monthly* 5, August 1859, pages 163-170. Interview from early 1859; consulted through Doctrine and Covenants Central's transcription. Participant testimony mediated by an interviewer. Read the interview.

[12] David Whitmer's late publication. *An Address to All Believers in Christ*, Richmond, Missouri, 1887, especially opening testimony and page 12 on the process. Self-published participant account, approximately fifty-eight years after 1829; consulted in an online transcription. Read the address.

[13] Three Witnesses statement. *Book of Mormon*, 1830 edition, page 589. Collective published testimony with Cowdery, Whitmer, and Harris named. Joseph Smith Papers. Read the statement.

[14] Eight Witnesses statement. *Book of Mormon*, 1830 edition, page 590. Collective published testimony concerning viewing and handling the plates. Joseph Smith Papers. Read the statement.

[15] Charles Anthon's contrary account. Letter to Eber D. Howe, February 17, 1834, printed in Howe, *Mormonism Unvailed*, 1834, pages 270-272. Retrospective account in a critical publication; consulted in a modern edited transcription. Read the letter.

[16] Joseph Smith's retrospective history. *Joseph Smith History* 1:27-60, 62-67, Pearl of Great Price. History begun in 1838; includes Smith's origin account, reported return of the plates, and the Harris account of Anthon. Official LDS text. Read the history.

[17] Claimed revelation concerning the loss. *Doctrine and Covenants* 10, especially verses 10-19 and 30-45. Official heading gives a likely April 1829 setting, with portions possibly dating to summer 1828. Evidence for the movement's explanation, not independent proof of a plot to alter the pages. Read section 10.

[18] LDS invitation to seek confirmation. *Moroni* 10:3-5, Book of Mormon. Read within its stated conditions of reflection, sincerity, intent, and faith in Christ. Read Moroni 10.

[19] Cowdery's attempted translation. *Doctrine and Covenants* 9:7-9, April 1829 setting. A distinct context from Moroni's invitation; used here to prevent conflation. Read section 9.

[20] Printing finance overview. Joseph Smith Papers, *Documents Volume 1 Part 2 Introduction April 1829 to March 1830*. Identifies Harris's August 25, 1829, mortgage and cites Wayne County, New York, Mortgage Records, volume 3, pages 325-326. Modern documentary overview, not a new inspection of the mortgage. Read the introduction.

[21] Biblical comparison. KJV: Exodus 28:30; Numbers 27:21; Deuteronomy 13:1-5 and 18:9-14; Luke 1:1-4; Acts 17:10-12; Galatians 1:6-9; First Corinthians 15:1-8; James 1:5; First John 4:1-3; Revelation 22:18-19. The applications in this file are the project's theological interpretation. Galatians 1, First John 4, Deuteronomy 18, First Corinthians 15.

[22] Official LDS witness overview. The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, *Witnesses of the Book of Mormon*, Church History Topics. Institutional presentation of the witness evidence and continuing affirmations. Read the overview.

Collection notes

Collection: LDS Origins and Authority. **Case:** 002. **Suggested route:** First Vision, then Book of Mormon Translation, then Book of Abraham. **Tags:** translation, Joseph Smith, manuscript, seer stone, interpreters, witnesses, lost 116 pages, revelation, scripture, evidence. **Related future study:** The Witnesses, for fuller individual source histories. **Editorial status:** Prepared case manuscript for content review.